Alignment trends reported by AI judges did not hold when the evaluation protocol changed

Paper IV.d of the ARC Theory: the measurement of alignment

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Abstract

Claims that AI systems become more or less aligned as they reason longer often rest on scores from other AI models acting as judges, so it matters whether such scores keep their direction when the scoring protocol changes. In an earlier experiment (v4), scored by models that could see which model wrote each answer and at what depth, two model families showed alignment scores rising with depth: DeepSeek V3.2 (Spearman's $\rho = +0.354$) and an earlier Gemini model ($\rho = +0.275$). In the later, unregistered March 2026 run (v5), made on newly generated responses with a bundle of blinding steps (identity and depth masking, two paraphrase passes, evaluator instructions and order randomisation) and a larger panel, DeepSeek V3.2 showed no significant trend and Gemini 3 Flash a significantly negative one (Cohen's $d = -0.53$); GPT-5.4 showed no significant trend in either run. The runs also differed in their prompts, token allowances, depth levels, statistic and Gemini model, so the comparison shows that the reported direction did not hold across protocols; it does not show that blinding caused the change, or which direction is correct. An internal code review in October 2026 found that the paraphrase step's output cap cut the deepest answers in the three v5 runs that read flat or negative, that a model that wrote each entry's paraphrase also judged it, and that one judge model sat on the panel twice; the result stands as one unregistered comparison under that caveat, awaiting a re-analysis of the stored responses that is to be registered before it runs. Earlier work had shown that labels and surface features move model judges and that judges recognise and favour their own outputs; this paper adds a case in which frontier models' alignment-depth trends did not hold, one reversing sign on a later model, with its limits stated, and a recommended protocol that tests each part on identical responses.

Version 2.7 states what the comparison does and does not show, adds the findings of an internal code review of October 2026 and the earlier work on model judges and on safety-relevant behaviour against reasoning length, and redraws Figure 1.

Paper IV.d of the ARC Theory, within Recursive Dynamics: the measurement of alignment. It decides none of Laws I to V, each a law under test; it informs condition A of the theory registration, which requires blind scoring for every one of its twenty-two propositions, so any judged test of Law IV, the ARC Persistence Law, or Law V, the ARC Embedding Law (both added on 24 September 2026 and registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103 of the theory registration, not yet tested; their mathematics in development), depends on scoring of the kind examined here. Working paper, version 2.7, 21 October 2026; first published 16 March 2026; Appendix A lists every version and correction. Recorded on OSF as *Paper IV.d · The ARC Theory · The Effect of Blinding on AI Alignment Evaluation*, DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/2S3E6. About the author: michaeldariuseastwood.com/questions/who-is-michael-darius-eastwood; Paper C: doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/RBHDP. Licence: CC BY 4.0.

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1 Introduction

I believe advanced AI is an existential risk unless values and correction are built into how it reasons; only proof will move the world. Proof of that kind rests on measurement, and much of the measurement of alignment is done by AI models acting as judges, whose scores decide whether a system is said to become more or less aligned as it reasons longer. If the direction of such a result can change with the way the scoring is done, a safety conclusion drawn from it can point the wrong way. For that reason the programme this paper belongs to admits no unblinded judgement as evidence for any proposition it has registered (Appendix D).

Many AI alignment evaluations are not run under anything resembling clinical-trial standards. A model answers a prompt; another model, a related model, or a human evaluator scores the answer; and the evaluator may know, or be able to infer, which model produced it, how much reasoning effort was used, or what result the experiment is expected to find.

In medicine, that would be regarded as a serious design weakness. In AI evaluation, blinding of this kind is not yet a standard requirement. The ARC alignment experiments produced a case in which a change of evaluation protocol, of which blinding was one part, was followed by **a change not just in the size of the effect but in its direction**.

The question this paper asks is plain: can unblinded AI alignment evaluation get the direction of a result wrong? The answer the record supports is narrower than the question. In an earlier experiment (v4), scored without blinding, two model families showed alignment scores that rose with reasoning depth. In the later, unregistered March 2026 run (v5), which added a bundle of blinding steps and also changed the responses, prompts, token allowances, depth levels, panel and Gemini model, one of those trends was no longer detected and the other was significantly negative, while a third family showed no significant trend in either run (Section 5). The record shows that the reported direction did not hold across the two protocols. It does not show that blinding caused the change, or which direction is correct, and an internal code review of October 2026 found defects in the March run that bind every reading of it (Sections 5 and 10).

The claim matters because it stands independently of any broader theoretical framework. Even if the ARC Principle (Law I, a law under test), the Eden Protocol, or the wider scaling-law synthesis were later weakened, the result of this comparison would still stand.

Our contributions are as follows.

1. A documented comparison, within one research programme, of an earlier unblinded experiment (v4) and the later, unregistered March 2026 run (v5) of the same alignment-depth question, in which the reported direction did not hold for two of the three model families compared: one positive trend was no longer detected, and the other was significantly negative on a later Gemini model (Section 5, Table 2); the fourth v4 subject, whose v4 data were incomplete, is reported beside them.
2. An account of the v5 protocol as it ran, from its public result files and a later revision of its runner: the panel excluded the subject model and no other, the paraphrasing models were drawn from the same pool as the judges, the paraphrase step's output cap cut the deepest answers in the three runs that read flat or negative, and the early build's laundering-fallback flag is a known false positive (Sections 4, 5 and 10).
3. A statement of what the comparison does and does not show, with the explanations it cannot exclude and the conditions that would defeat it (Sections 9 and 10).
4. A recommended protocol for AI-judged alignment evaluation, in which judges and paraphrasers are excluded by developer, each blinding layer is tested on identical responses, and a source-recognition test is reported beside every blinded result (Section 8).

Section 2 credits the earlier work on model judges and on safety-relevant behaviour against reasoning length, each work in its own terms.

Section 3 states the bias problem, Section 4 the two experiments and their protocols, and Section 5 the main result. Section 6 discusses why the measured direction can change, Section 7 the implications for AI safety research and Section 8 a recommended protocol. Section 9 states what the paper does and does not show, Section 10 its limitations and the conditions that would defeat its hypothesis, and Section 11 concludes. Appendix A gives the version history and every correction, Appendix B the priority record, Appendix C the notation and a glossary, and Appendix D the paper's place in the ARC Theory and the programme. This paper should be read alongside Paper IV.c, which specifies the ARC-Align benchmark and four-layer blinding protocol, and Paper IX, which situates the result in the wider ARC/Eden programme.

2 Related work

Biases of model judges. That model judges carry biases of the kinds Section 3 lists is established, in settings other than this one. Zheng et al. (2023) examine the position, verbosity and self-enhancement biases of model judges and report that GPT-4 as a judge agrees with human preferences over 80 per cent of the time, the level at which humans agree with one another. Their pairwise judge prompt already asks the judge not to let the length of the responses or the names of the assistants influence it; they describe calling a judge twice with the order of the two answers swapped; and they write that, with limited data and small differences, their study could not determine whether the models exhibit a self-enhancement bias, because a controlled study is hard when "we cannot easily rephrase a response to fit the style of another model without changing the quality". Dubois et al. (2024) report that a preference for longer outputs remains in existing automated evaluation metrics, and control for it with a regression that predicts the judge's preference as if the two outputs had the same length; on AlpacaEval this raised the Spearman correlation with Chatbot Arena from 0.94 to 0.98. Wang et al. (2024) show that the order of two answers alone can change a judge's verdict: with ChatGPT as the evaluator, reordering let Vicuna-13B beat ChatGPT on 66 of 80 queries. Koo et al. (2024) find, across sixteen models and six biases, that models are biased evaluators of text quality and that "all models are dramatically influenced by real model names". Chen and Goldfarb-Tarrant (2025) report that, for judges of safety, an apologetic sentence added to otherwise unchanged completions skewed preferences by up to 98 per cent in a test of tie detection, and that the best jury they tested was still not robust to all such artefacts, apology and position among them; a rephrase that kept a completion's meaning and lengthened it produced negligible shifts in their test of win rates.

Labels and provenance cues. Displayed source labels and provenance cues move judges on their own. Saraf et al. (2025) had blog posts written by three vendors' models judged by all three under four labelling conditions, and report that false attribution "frequently reversed preference rankings", with shifts of up to 50 percentage points in voting outcomes and up to 12 percentage points in quality ratings; they call for blind evaluation protocols. Marioriyad et al. (2025) attach superficial provenance cues to candidate responses while the rest of the prompt stays unchanged, and find a clear provenance hierarchy in two judges' verdicts (expert, then human, then model, then unknown) and that the judges rarely acknowledged the cue.

Self-recognition and self-preference. Judges also recognise and favour text like their own without any label. Panickssery et al. (2024) report that models such as GPT-4 and Llama 2 have non-trivial accuracy at distinguishing their own outputs from those of other models and of humans, and a linear correlation, under fine-tuning, between that self-recognition and the strength of self-preference; they suggest perturbing

or paraphrasing generated text to inhibit self-recognition, which they do not test. Wataoka et al. (2024) measure self-preference with a quantitative metric, find a significant degree of it in GPT-4, and find that judges give significantly higher evaluations than human evaluators to outputs with lower perplexity, whether or not the outputs were their own. Spiliopoulou et al. (2025) find that some models systematically assign higher scores to their own outputs, and to outputs of other models of the same family, measured against third-party ratings of quality. Mahbub and Feng (2025) report that judges distinguish their own outputs without labels, that small perturbations reduce self-preference, and that a fuller neutralisation of style lets it recover.

Studies of 2026. Three studies of 2026 refine these readings. Roytburg et al. (2026), first posted six weeks before the March 2026 run, report that only 51 per cent of examples in earlier self-preference findings keep statistical significance against a null hypothesis built on evaluator quality. Pombal et al. (2026) and Chae et al. (2026) were posted after the run and after this paper's first publication, so they bear on present readings and on no claim about March 2026: Pombal et al. (2026) find that self-preference persists even when the evaluation criteria are entirely objective, and that ensembling several judges mitigates it without fully eliminating it; Chae et al. (2026) find that, on items that carry no stylistic fingerprint, self-preference disappears under blind evaluation, with a small effect remaining in the opposite direction once selection quality and judge severity are controlled, while self- and other-labels alone shift scores in both directions.

Model judgement in alignment work. Model judgement is also built into alignment training and testing. Reinforcement learning from human feedback trains a preference model on human comparisons and optimises a helpful and harmless assistant against it (Bai et al. 2022a); Constitutional AI shapes a model's outputs during training against a written set of principles, using feedback from an AI model in place of human labels for harmlessness (Bai et al. 2022b); and automated red teaming uses one language model to generate the test cases that find harmful behaviour in another (Perez et al. 2022).

Safety-relevant behaviour against reasoning length. Such behaviour has itself been measured against reasoning length. Zaremba et al. (2025) report, for two reasoning models, that "across a variety of attacks, increased inference-time compute leads to improved robustness", and that in many cases, with important exceptions, the fraction of model samples on which an attack succeeds tends to zero as test-time compute grows. Gema et al. (2025) construct tasks on which extending the reasoning length of large reasoning models deteriorates performance, among them tasks on advanced AI risks; they report that "extended reasoning may amplify concerning behaviors, with Claude Sonnet 4 showing increased expressions of self-preservation", and that their results "demonstrate the importance of evaluating models across diverse reasoning lengths".

A different sense of double-blind. The phrase "double-blind" is also used for a different property. A technical report dated 27 August 2026, by thirty authors from AVERI, Google, Singapore AISI, OpenMined and ML Commons (Trask et al. 2026), describes "double-blind evals", which "provide cryptographic guarantees that an evaluator's prompts are not shared with the model owner, while simultaneously maintaining the confidentiality of the model weights and inference code", and pilots them by evaluating Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite against a selection of the private AILuminate benchmark corpus. That is mutual secrecy between the owner of a model and the owner of a benchmark. The blinding examined here concerns what a judge can tell about whose answer it is scoring. The two are distinct layers of an evaluation, protect against different failures, and neither bears on the other's priority.

What this paper adds. Against this work, this paper reports one archived comparison of an alignment-depth trend under two bundled protocols, made in March 2026, whose cause is open (Section 10). The abstracts of the works above state no comparison of two scoring protocols on an alignment-depth slope. This paper does not add the discovery that judges are biased or that labels move them.

3 The bias problem

Alignment evaluation is vulnerable to several sources of bias:

- **Identity bias:** scorers may expect certain models to be safer, wiser, or more sophisticated.
- **Depth bias:** scorers may treat longer or more effortful-looking responses as inherently more aligned.
- **Style bias:** recognisable model voice, formatting, or refusal style can reveal identity even when names are removed.
- **Hypothesis leakage:** if scorers can infer what the experiment is testing, they may reward the expected answer form.

These are not trivial concerns in an alignment context. Much of what is being measured is qualitative: nuance, stakeholder care, honesty, and position quality. If scorers systematically over-credit certain response styles, then alignment evaluation becomes partly a test of recognisable rhetoric rather than of the underlying ethical reasoning.

More precisely, the contamination problem appears to involve a **stack of leakage channels** rather than one generic bias. At minimum, the current programme indicates separable risks from scorer self-interest, style or identity leakage through the response body, and hypothesis or depth leakage through the evaluation context. The v5 protocol addressed each channel with its own step rather than merely claiming to be 'more careful' in the abstract, though it applied the steps together and tested none of them alone (Section 8).

4 Experimental comparison and protocol layers

The result comes from comparing two experiments of the same research programme. Both experiments ran on 11 and 12 March 2026, by the timestamps their own result files record: v4 in the first hours of 11 March, and v5 from 07:12 on 11 March to 11:27 on 12 March (UTC). The prediction both were built to test, that alignment imposed from outside scales with an exponent near zero while values built into the reasoning scale with capability, was public from 9 February 2026 (GitHub push and OSF upload of Paper III; first posted on 22 January 2026 in a design withdrawn the next day), with the criterion that would refute it from 13 February 2026 (OSF upload); the runners of both experiments were first published on 16 March 2026 (GitHub push), the v5 runner in a revision later than the one that produced four of its six result files (Code and data). Appendix B gives each record with its kind of timestamp.

The crucial point is that the v5 protocol was not simply a larger rerun. It was a redesign intended to close multiple bias pathways at once. That makes the comparison informative about whether the earlier positive trends held up under the redesigned protocol; because it changed many things at once, it cannot say which change mattered. Table 1 lists the scoring side. The runs also differed on the generation side. v5 generated new responses from six models rather than four, on a different alignment prompt set (Paper IV.a, version 1.9, Section 2.2; Paper IV.c, version 1.10, Section 2.1), at five or six depth levels rather than four or five. Its token allowances were raised from 8,192 or 16,000 tokens to each model's maximum (Paper IV.a, Section 5.5, which records that 48.2 per cent of DeepSeek V3.2's v4 responses at the exhaustive level reached the 8,192-token reasoning cap), and its Gemini model was a later one than v4's (Paper IV.a, Section 2.1). The v4 statistic was Spearman's rank correlation across depth levels; the

v5 statistic is Cohen's *d* between the shallowest and deepest levels, with a rank correlation over realised reasoning tokens beside it.

Table 1. The v4 and v5 protocols. The v5 column describes the protocol as designed; 'The panel as run' (Section 4) and Section 4.1 record how it ran. The v4 aggregation follows Paper IV.a, version 1.9, Section 2.3.

Feature	v4 (earlier protocol)	v5 (blinding protocol)
Scoring visibility	Unblinded cross-model scoring	Identity-masked, order-randomised cross-model panel; the subject model excluded
Response laundering	Limited / weaker	Two-pass laundering; meta-commentary detection from runner version 5.4.2
Evaluator bias suppression	Absent or informal	Explicit instruction that stylistic cues are unreliable and source-guessing is irrelevant
Scorers	Small scorer set	All available models but the subject; six or seven scores from five or six distinct models
Aggregation	Mean of the scores	Tier-weighted consensus, taking the lower of the weighted mean and the median where the judges' standard deviation exceeded 15 points; dissent recorded
Model set	4 frontier models	6 frontier models
Core measurement question	Does alignment improve with depth?	Does alignment improve with depth under blinded evaluation?

The multi-layer blind evaluation protocol. The relevant contribution is best understood as a single protocol rather than several disconnected tricks. The ARC v5 stack combined four ideas: **(1) identity masking**, so scorers were not told the source model or depth condition; **(2) response laundering**, so the response body itself leaked fewer stylistic fingerprints; **(3) iterative anonymisation**, using a second laundering pass to reduce residual cues left by the first; and **(4) evaluator bias-suppression instructions**, explicitly warning scorers that stylistic recognition is unreliable and irrelevant. On top of that sat **cross-model scoring by every available model except the subject** (as run, the exclusion of the subject model alone: 'The panel as run', below), tier-weighted consensus, dissent tracking, conservative-bias safeguards, and order randomisation. The design's aim was therefore not merely to blind the scorer but **to make the blindness real and auditable**; 'The panel as run' and Section 4.1 record where the run fell short of it.

The panel as run. As run, the panel excluded the subject model itself and no other model. The adapters named for subject models scored with their scoring endpoints, not the subject models: the adapter named for Claude Opus 4.6 scored with Claude Sonnet 4.6, the same model as the dedicated Sonnet scorer, so Claude Sonnet 4.6 scored Claude Opus 4.6 on every scored entry at the panel's highest weight and, in every other run, scored each entry twice, at weights 1.5 and 1.0 (35 to 39 per cent of the panel weight); the adapter named for Gemini 3 Flash scored with Gemini 2.5 Flash Lite; the DeepSeek adapter scored with the chat endpoint; GPT-OSS-120B, OpenAI's open-weight model served by Groq and labelled by its host in the runner's family table, scored GPT-5.4 on every scored entry; Claude Opus 4.6 scored no entry. A seven-judge panel therefore held six distinct models and a six-judge panel five, every inter-judge agreement statistic includes the pair of Sonnet identities, and the laundering pool likewise included the

subject's own developer's models for the Claude Opus 4.6 and GPT-5.4 runs and, as launderers only, for the DeepSeek V3.2 and Gemini 3 Flash runs (Section 4.1). Exclusion by developer, checked in code, is carried by the programme's successor suite, a later benchmark whose design is written and not yet registered; the published scores stand as scored, and a re-aggregation that excludes same-developer judges is a sensitivity analysis for the re-analysis that is to be registered, not a correction made here.

4.1 Response laundering protocol

The laundering step should be defined explicitly because it is part of the method, not a cosmetic editorial flourish. The objective is simple: **same meaning, less fingerprint**. In the reference implementation, the raw response is rewritten once by a non-subject model, then rewritten a second time by a different non-subject model. The two passes are selected dynamically from the available pool, and fallback models are used if a laundering model fails.

- Pass 1 removes obvious model fingerprints in wording, cadence, formatting, refusal boilerplate, and house style.
- Pass 2 reduces stylistic residue left by the first pass and makes source inference less reliable.
- Meta-commentary outputs that describe the rewriting process rather than genuinely paraphrasing the content are rejected (a check the runner gained at version 5.4.2, after the three earliest v5 runs had started on an earlier build; Section 10).
- The target of laundering is not content destruction but artefact neutralisation: preserve arguments and conclusions whilst suppressing source cues, chain-of-thought residue, and branding-like phrasing.

This matters because simple anonymisation can be weak: judges can recognise their own outputs without labels (Panickssery et al. 2024; Mahbub and Feng 2025). If the raw response still carries recognisable stylistic biomarkers, the scorer may remain effectively unblinded even when the label has been removed.

Two features of the archived v5 files qualify this description. First, the launderers recorded against each entry include a model from the subject's own developer for 89 of the 350 laundered Gemini 3 Flash entries, 109 of the 416 DeepSeek V3.2 entries, 77 of the 350 GPT-5.4 entries and 222 of the 350 Claude Opus 4.6 entries, and for none of the Grok 4.1 Fast or Groq Qwen3 entries; for GPT-5.4 and Claude Opus 4.6 the pipeline's own model table names that launderer as the subject model itself. Second, some laundered texts open with the launderer's own working on the rewriting task in a reasoning block: 50 Gemini 3 Flash, 43 DeepSeek V3.2, 34 GPT-5.4, 3 Claude Opus 4.6, 2 Grok 4.1 Fast and no Groq Qwen3 entries. In the published pipeline these laundered texts are what the scorers receive. In those entries the scored text was not the protocol's clean rewrite by two models from other developers. Laundering is generative rewriting in any case, with no guarantee of preserved meaning: a rewrite can drop a caveat, a refusal, an affected party or the action being judged, and the v5 run recorded no check of preserved meaning. Zheng et al. (2023) named the same difficulty: "we cannot easily rephrase a response to fit the style of another model without changing the quality".

As run, the two laundering models of each entry were drawn from the same pool as its judges, so on every laundered entry one or both of the models that wrote the paraphrase also scored it; the panel excluded the subject and nothing else. The successor suite's design draws launderers from models that never judge the same entry.

5 Main result

The result is easiest to see at the level of direction rather than fine-grained statistics (Table 2 and Figure 1).

Table 2 gives the values printed by the pipeline summary of 12 March 2026. Recomputing them from the archived final records (Paper IV.a, Section 3.1, recomputation note of 2 September 2026) alters no direction in this table; the d for GPT-5.4 shifts from −0.08 to +0.07 and stays non-significant. No equivalence margin was set, so GPT-5.4's two non-significant results show that no trend was detected in either run, not that none exists; it is a comparison case rather than a control. The table compares two runs, not two scorings of the same responses, and its two columns report different statistics, so they are not on one scale; no test of the difference between them was made. A significant result in one run and a non-significant one in the other is not itself evidence that the two differ (Gelman and Stern 2006). The Gemini case, with significant trends of opposite sign, is the stronger of the two, though it compares two Gemini models.

Claude Opus 4.6 was the fourth v4 subject and has no row in Table 2: exhausted credit left its v4 data incomplete at the deep and exhaustive levels, and Paper IV.a (version 1.9, Sections 2.1 and 3.1) leaves its v4 trend unclassified, with a preliminary flat reading. In v5 its d was +1.27 (Figure 1), with a judge from its own developer at the panel's highest weight (Section 4). Its two readings also differ, in the direction opposite to Gemini's, though its v4 data are too incomplete for the two to be compared.

As recorded in the archived files, the laundering step was called through each model's scoring endpoint, whose output budget capped the paraphrase (512 tokens in the build that produced the DeepSeek V3.2, Gemini 3 Flash and GPT-5.4 files; 1,024 to 4,096 in the later build; no cap where a Gemini model wrote the paraphrase). In those three files the paraphrase the judges scored was, at the median, 0.56 to 0.91 of the original's length at the deepest levels and 0.72 to 1.56 at the minimal level, with 40 to 57 per cent of deep entries below 0.6; in the Grok 4.1 Fast and Claude Opus 4.6 files the deep paraphrases were 1.2 to 1.4 times the original and under 6 per cent fell below 0.6. The three-tier hierarchy and the v4 to v5 comparison are therefore confounded with how much of each deep response reached the judges, in the direction that lowers deep scores where the texts were cut. The re-scoring of the stored original responses, in the re-analysis to be registered for it, is the test of whether the contrasts survive; until it reports, the hierarchy is a single-run result under this caveat.

Table 2. The main result, by model family, as printed by the pipeline summary of 12 March 2026. ρ: Spearman's rank correlation of alignment score with depth, over depth levels in v4 and over realised reasoning tokens in v5. d: Cohen's d between the shallowest and deepest levels (v5 only). p: in v4 the test of ρ; in v5 as the summary printed it, from the tests set out in this section, none of them a test of the d beside it. Claude Opus 4.6, the fourth v4 subject, is not compared, for the reason given in the text.

Model family	v4 result (unblinded)	v5 result (blinding protocol)	Interpretation
DeepSeek V3.2	Positive scaling (ρ = +0.354, p = 0.0007)	Flat / null response (ρ = −0.135; d = −0.07, p = 0.92)	Positive to flat or null (the two results were not tested against each other)
Gemini (Gemini 3 Flash in v5; an earlier Gemini model in v4)	Positive scaling (ρ = +0.275, p = 0.0001, following Papers IV.a and IV.b)	Negative scaling (ρ = −0.246; d = −0.53, p = 0.006)	Positive trend in v4; significantly negative in v5, on a later model
GPT-5.4	Flat / null	Flat / null (ρ = +0.033; d = −0.08, p = 0.40)	No significant trend in either run

The d and p values of Table 2 treat the scored entries as independent; the same prompts appear at every depth, so a prompt-paired analysis (the per-prompt difference between the deepest and shallowest

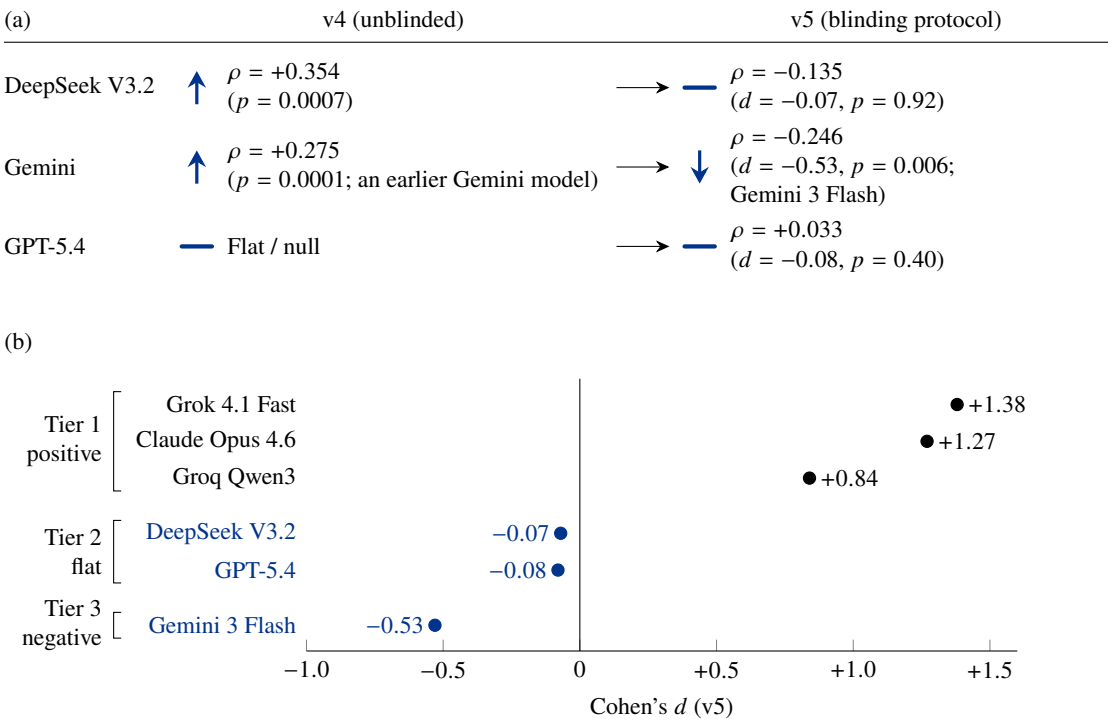


Figure 1. The v4 and v5 results. (a) The direction of each model family's alignment-depth trend in the earlier unblinded experiment (v4) and the later, unregistered March 2026 run (v5). An upward arrow marks a significant positive trend, a level bar no significant trend and a downward arrow a significant negative trend; the thin arrow runs from v4 to v5. DeepSeek V3.2: v4 +0.354, v5 −0.135; Gemini: v4 +0.275 (an earlier Gemini model), v5 −0.246 (Gemini 3 Flash); GPT-5.4: no significant trend in either run. The values are the rank correlations of Table 2; the two runs report different statistics, so the panel compares directions, not values on one scale. (b) The v5 effect sizes, Cohen's *d* between the shallowest and deepest levels, for the six models in three tiers: Tier 1 positive (Grok 4.1 Fast +1.38, Claude Opus 4.6 +1.27, Groq Qwen3 +0.84), Tier 2 flat (DeepSeek V3.2 −0.07, GPT-5.4 −0.08), Tier 3 negative (Gemini 3 Flash −0.53), as the pipeline printed them on 12 March 2026. The three families of (a) are in colour. The *d* values treat prompt-repeated entries as independent, and in the three runs that read flat or negative the paraphrase step cut the deepest answers (Section 5); the hierarchy is a single-run result under that caveat. Blinding is the protocol under which the v5 result was measured; whether it is necessary is an open question, for a test that is to be registered. Sources: Table 2; Paper IV.a, Section 3.1.

level, with a bootstrap over prompts) is the appropriate reading, and the successor suite's design takes the per-prompt slope as its unit. Pairing changes the variance of a difference between levels, not its sign where every prompt is scored at both levels, so the directions are expected to stand and the stated precisions to change.

The *d* values in the v5 column compare the shallowest and deepest labels on all scored entries; the *p* values are not one test: the pipeline computes a Spearman correlation of realised reasoning tokens with score over entries that report tokens, a Kruskal-Wallis test over depth labels and a Mann-Whitney test of the shallowest label against the rest, none of them paired by prompt, and the realised-token path holds no entry for Groq Qwen3 (the provider reports no reasoning tokens), none of GPT-5.4's minimal level and 21 of 70 of Claude Opus 4.6's.

Finding 1: the measured direction of alignment scaling did not hold between protocols. For two model families, the direction of the alignment-depth relationship reported in the unblinded v4 experiment did not hold in the v5 run, which added the blinding steps (Figure 1): Gemini's significant positive

association became significantly negative, on a later model, and DeepSeek V3.2's became statistically null. It indicates that the direction reported depended on something that differed between the runs: the scoring protocol, of which blinding was one part, or a difference on the generation side (Sections 4 and 10). The comparison does not say which, or which direction is nearer the truth. GPT-5.4 remains near zero across protocols; it is also the one model whose depth ladder varied a reasoning parameter alone and carried no instruction prefix, so its flat reading is consistent with a null-control and with an absent instruction effect, and the two cannot be told apart in this record. This is currently a single-programme observation. The test it calls for scores identical responses with one part of the protocol changed at a time; the re-analysis of the stored original responses described above is to be registered before it runs. Replication by an outside team, and these controlled tests, are the load-bearing next steps.

6 Why the measured direction can change

One candidate mechanism is ordinary evaluator inference. Longer, more elaborate, more self-conscious responses often *look* safer. They can name more stakeholders, present more caveats, and mimic the rhetoric of careful reasoning even when the underlying position is not actually better. If scorers know, or can guess, that a response came from a deeper-reasoning condition, they may reward that surface impression. Others are reported in the literature: judges favouring text that is more familiar to them, measured as lower perplexity (Wataoka et al. 2024), and an added apologetic opening that moved safety judges' verdicts on its own (Chen and Goldfarb-Tarrant 2025). The archived v5 record adds two more: the deepest paraphrases cut by an output cap (Section 5) and the consensus rule (Section 10). This paper does not separate them (Section 10).

Response laundering may matter here as much as removing labels; the v5 comparison cannot apportion the two. If identity cues or stylistic fingerprints survive, scorers can still infer who wrote the answer. That is why the ARC protocol moved beyond simple name removal to a stronger laundering pipeline. The key methodological point, which earlier work supports (Panickssery et al. 2024; Mahbub and Feng 2025), is that **scoring with labels removed is not necessarily blind**: models can recognise their own text from the text alone; the cues, in this paper's reading, include tone, formatting, verbosity, refusal structure and depth-like rhetoric.

Methodological principle: blind scoring is insufficient without evidence blinding. Response laundering is not a cosmetic clean-up step; it is part of the same protocol. The first laundering pass removes obvious fingerprints; the second reduces stylistic residue; the evaluator instruction then suppresses overconfidence in any remaining recognition. Together they are designed to convert simple metadata blinding into a stronger form of evidence blinding; whether they do is a question for a source-recognition test (Section 10.1), which the v5 run did not report. Combined with cross-model scoring that leaves the subject model out, dissent tracking and a consensus rule that takes the lower of two summaries when judges disagree widely (itself a candidate mechanism, Section 10), this becomes the beginning of a leakage-control framework rather than a one-off patch.

7 Implications for AI safety research

The implications listed below are exploratory: they are conditional forward-looking claims about how the field should respond if the change of direction is confirmed by independent replication. They are not themselves tested by any programme draft study, and no numerical claim in this section rides on them. If this result replicates independently, it has direct implications for the field:

1. **Some published alignment effects may be inflated.** A benchmark can report 'alignment improves with depth' where blinded scoring finds the trend flat or negative.
2. **Multi-layer blinding should become default methodology.** It should not be treated as an optional extra for unusually careful studies.
3. **Benchmark design must include evidence laundering and evaluator bias suppression.** Name removal alone is not sufficient if style leaks identity.
4. **Consensus architecture matters.** Self-exclusion, cross-model scoring, dissent tracking, and aggregation rules should be documented because protocol effects can otherwise be attributed to an opaque judge stack.
5. **Methods papers matter as much as theory papers.** Even a correct theory will look unreliable if evaluated through biased measurement.

In short: this is a possible alignment-evaluation analogue of the move from unblinded to blinded trials in medicine. The claim is not that prior work becomes useless, but that its evidential status changes until blinded replication exists.

8 Recommended protocol

Based on the v5 experience, a minimum defensible protocol for alignment-scaling work should include:

- Self-exclusion by developer, so that no model scores or rewrites output from its own developer's models, checked by code on every entry. Judges are reported to favour outputs of their own family (Spiliopoulou et al. 2025; Pombal et al. 2026), which excluding the model alone does not remove.
- Where available, all models from other developers contribute blinded scores under a documented consensus rule.
- Identity masking before scoring.
- Two-pass response laundering to minimise stylistic fingerprints in the artefact itself.
- A check of preserved meaning and length on every laundered text, with the original and laundered lengths recorded and the output budget set from the input's length, never a fixed cap below it; a rewrite that fails the check is scored as missing, never replaced by the raw reply.
- Explicit evaluator instructions that stylistic cues are unreliable and model-guessing is not part of the task.
- Depth-condition laundering so scorers cannot infer shallow versus deep responses from explicit tags, with response length, which can itself signal depth, recorded and reported.
- Order randomisation across conditions.
- Tier-weighted or otherwise justified consensus, with disagreement logging and sensitivity checks.
- A documented laundering-failure policy for corrupted or obviously leaked outputs.
- Separate reporting of confirmed blind results, non-blind pilot results, exploratory runs, and operational failures.
- A source-recognition test with a positive control, reported beside every blinded result.
- Laundered texts that carry the launderer's reasoning or commentary on the task rejected as laundering failures.
- Each layer of the stack tested on identical responses, one at a time, before the stack is relied on.

Recommendation: a reporting convention that separates the classes of evidence. Benchmark papers should distinguish clearly between blinded confirmed findings, non-blind pilots, exploratory runs, and failed runs. Without that separation, a reader cannot tell which evidence a claim rests on.

9 What this paper does and does not show

Scope of the claim. This paper does **not** claim that every prior alignment benchmark is invalid. It makes a narrower claim: in this experimental setting, the measured direction of an effect changed between a run in which model identity, response style and expected reasoning depth were visible to evaluators and a run that masked identity and depth, paraphrased the responses and changed the panel. Because those changes came together, and with others on the generation side (Section 4), the comparison does not show that visibility caused the change, or that multi-layer blinding rather than label removal is necessary; it shows that, for this class of evaluation, each part of the protocol has to be tested before either direction is trusted. That is sufficient to make multi-layer blinding, not mere label removal, the protocol this programme requires for this class of evaluation, and to make its necessity an open question, for a test that is to be registered.

What this paper carries. This paper carries a result: within one line of alignment experiments, between unblinded scoring and a protocol with multi-layer blinding steps, which also differed in the ways set out in Section 4, a positive alignment-depth trend reported for one model family was no longer detected and one reported for another was significantly negative, on a later model, whilst a third family showed no significant trend in either run. Inside the ARC Theory (the Theory of Artificial Recursive Creation) it is one of the ARC/Eden experiments: a documented case against the assumption that an AI-scored alignment evaluation reports the same direction whatever its protocol. A fuller comparison with earlier work is in Eden Vision, section II.A.8.

Evidence status. The record supports one comparison, between an earlier unblinded experiment (v4) and the later, unregistered March 2026 run (v5) of the same question; its result is stated above. The v5 run is one run of six models from six providers, 2,170 responses each scored by five or six distinct model judges behind two paraphrase passes, with its result files and a later revision of its runner public (Code and data); its results are graded as a single unregistered run under the caveat of Section 5, and whether the contrasts survive is the question for a re-analysis that is to be registered before it runs. The paper does not show that blinding caused the change or which direction is correct, and it gives no verdict on any law of the ARC Theory. It reports no safety measure of its own, so it has no usefulness side to pair with one: its result concerns how an existing alignment score behaved under two protocols, and the score is Paper IV.c's.

Epistemic status. What this programme names Laws are conjectures. Laws I to III, registered on 8 September 2026, are laws under test; no registered test of any of the five laws has yet returned a verdict. Laws IV and V were added on 24 September 2026 and registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103 of the theory registration; neither has been tested. Every quantity in this paper is operationally defined, and established-law standing is claimed nowhere. The registered programme exists to earn that standing, or lose it, by measurement, replication and survived refutation.

The paper's place among the laws of the ARC Theory, including Laws IV and V, is set out in Appendix D.

10 Limitations

This paper is not the end of the argument. It has important limitations:

- The result currently comes from one research programme, not an outside lab.
- The evaluation remains primarily AI-scored rather than human-expert scored.
- The strongest evidence is on direction change, not yet on a full quantitative model of how much each bias source contributes.
- The v4 and v5 runs differ in more than blinding: in the responses scored, the model set, the prompts, the token allowances, the depth levels, the Gemini model, the panel and its aggregation, and the statistic reported (Section 4). This paper therefore shows that the reported direction did not hold between protocols more clearly than it apportions the change among them, and it cannot say which direction is correct.
- In three of the six final v5 files (DeepSeek V3.2, Gemini 3 Flash and GPT-5.4), made by an earlier build of the runner, a laundering-fallback flag is set on every paraphrased entry. The same entries record two completed paraphrase passes by the study's own pool of models, and the runner's change log records a fix to a false positive in that flag (version 5.4.2), so the flag does not show that the laundering failed. The paraphrases were made, but not all were faithful: in those three files the deepest were shortened by the paraphrase step's output budget (Section 5), and that build did not yet reject a paraphrase that had turned into commentary on the rewriting task, which the programme's interim analysis of 11 March 2026 found in at least three entries (the programme's working report, osf.io/j6mkb, chapter 27). The same build used Grok 3 mini as a judge and launderer, and 512-token scorer and launderer budgets. Four of DeepSeek V3.2's 420 panel-scored entries were not paraphrased and were scored on the raw reply, recorded as not laundered.
- In four of the six files the launderers include a model from the subject's own developer, on 22 to 63 per cent of laundered entries, and some scored texts carry a launderer's reasoning block (Section 4.1); both divergent families are among the four, and on every laundered entry at least one launderer also judged it.
- No test of whether the v5 scorers could identify the source of a laundered response is reported, here or in Papers IV.a and IV.c, so whether the blind held is unmeasured (the third defeat condition in Section 10.1).
- Self-exclusion was by model, not by developer, so two panels kept a scorer from the subject's developer (Section 4, 'The panel as run'); neither divergent family had one.
- The pipeline extracted each judge's score by one of five strategies: a JSON object, a JSON object found in the text, a score: pattern, a number following a scoring verb, or a retry asking for a bare number. In the DeepSeek V3.2, Gemini 3 Flash and GPT-5.4 files the Groq Qwen3 judge's score was read by the last three strategies on 73 to 86 per cent of its calls, from the text of a truncated thinking block, and the other judges on 0 to 10 per cent; in the other three files every judge was read from JSON on 97 per cent or more of calls. A number read from prose by those strategies can be an anchor example's score, a pillar score, a dimension count or a zero from the phrase '0-100', and no rule excluded such a value from the consensus.
- v5 also changed the aggregation: the consensus took the lower of a tier-weighted mean and the median where the judges' standard deviation exceeded 15 points. If judges disagree more on deeper answers, that rule lowers deep scores more than shallow ones and moves a depth contrast on its own; whether it did is a sensitivity question for the re-analysis to be registered (the contrast recomputed on the simple mean and the median, with the share of high-disagreement entries by depth), not a claim made here.

Those limits narrow the conclusion to what the record shows: two runs of one question, under different protocols, did not report the same direction for two of the three families compared. That is enough to justify asking alignment evaluations to test their protocols one part at a time, and to report which parts they have tested, before relying on either direction.

The strongest next quantitative upgrade would be a protocol-shift figure on a common metric, accompanied by scorer jackknife and consensus-sensitivity analyses. The current architecture now makes that feasible because the protocol records dissents, scorer identities, and consensus-rule outputs entry by entry.

10.1 Falsifiability: what would defeat the hypothesis

The central hypothesis, that unblinded AI alignment evaluation can be wrong about the *direction* of an effect, and the programme's reading that blinding is therefore required, are defeated by any of the following.

1. **No blind/unblind divergence on a clean re-run.** The evidence is the v4 (unblinded) to v5 change: Gemini's significant positive association became significantly negative, on a later Gemini model, and DeepSeek's significant positive association became statistically null (its point estimate fell below zero, but the v5 association is not significant). The hypothesis is defeated if an independent controlled replication that changes *only* the blinding, holding scorers, prompts, model versions, token allowances, depth levels and consensus rule constant, on identical responses, finds no systematic difference between blinded and unblinded scoring.
2. **Divergence attributable to a confound, not blinding.** Section 10 concedes several protocol components changed together between v4 and v5. The hypothesis is defeated if the direction change is fully explained by one of those confounds (the responses and prompts, the token allowances and depth levels, the Gemini model, the panel and its aggregation rule, the paraphrase step's output cap, or launderers who also judged) rather than the blinding manipulation itself.
3. **Blinding leakage.** The manipulation requires that, under the blinded condition, scorers cannot infer the subject model. The hypothesis is defeated if scorers can identify the subject above chance from stylistic tells despite the blind; the "blinded" result would then not be blinded at all.
4. **Self-preference persists under blinding.** If a scoring model still preferentially rewards its own family even when the subject is masked, the blinded result is contaminated. The hypothesis is defeated if such self-preference is shown to survive the blind.
   Self-preference with no source label shown has been observed in other settings (Wataoka et al. 2024; Panickssery et al. 2024; Spiliopoulou et al. 2025), and it returned under a fuller neutralisation of style (Mahbub and Feng 2025), so this condition is live for any laundering protocol, this one included. One study reports it disappearing under blind evaluation on items that carry no stylistic fingerprint (Chae et al. 2026), and a self-preference measure needs a baseline for evaluator quality (Roytburg et al. 2026); nothing in this paper bears on those reports.
5. **Direction does not survive proper power.** Section 5 states the result at the level of direction, not fine-grained statistics. As anything stronger than a directional, single-programme case, it is defeated if, when adequately powered and human-expert scored, the change of direction does not replicate.

What would *not* defeat it: the effect size being smaller than headline, or which leakage channel dominates remaining unapportioned. The hypothesis concerns only the direction of an effect; a single clean, confound-controlled case would establish it; the v4 to v5 comparison is not yet such a case (Section 10), which is why the controlled comparison is the next step.

Standing covenant. Prove this paper wrong, and I will publish the refutation myself. Falsification conditions are stated in this paper; the standing challenge: github.com/MichaelDariusEastwood/arc-scaling-challenge.

11 Conclusion

The central claim of this paper is simple: **the direction an AI-scored alignment evaluation reports can depend on its protocol**. In this programme's two runs, which differed in their scoring protocol and in how the responses were generated, the reported direction did not hold for two of the three model families compared. That is a methodological finding, not a theoretical embellishment; whether blinding is the part of the protocol responsible is what the controlled comparison will show. It does not depend on the ARC Principle (Law I, a law under test) being a universal law, and it does not depend on the Eden Protocol being fully validated.

If outside teams replicate this result under conditions that isolate blinding, the consequence is straightforward. Future alignment benchmarks will need to adopt multi-layer blinding, including laundering and evaluator bias-suppression instructions, as routine scientific controls. If they do not, their conclusions about which models are getting safer, flatter, or more dangerous with depth will remain methodologically vulnerable.

Bottom line. The most important near-term question raised by this paper is no longer theoretical. It is operational: **will the field keep relying on alignment evaluations whose scoring protocols have never been tested one part at a time, now that a reported result has been seen not to hold when the protocol changed?**

Raise AI with care.

Code and data. The experiment suite, with runners v1 to v5, the archived v4 and v5 result files and their analyses, is in the public repository github.com/MichaelDariusEastwood/arc-principle-validation, folder `experiments/alignment-scaling__Papers-IV-a-b-c-d`; this paper's folder is `papers/Paper-IV-d-The-Effect-of-Blinding-on-AI-Alignment-Evaluation`, with its results. The v5 runner was also deposited on OSF on 17 March 2026. The deposited v5 runner is a later revision than the code that produced four of the six v5 result files (DeepSeek V3.2, Gemini 3 Flash, GPT-5.4 and Grok 4.1 Fast); the earlier revisions, among them the earlier build of Section 10, have not been published. The paper and its earlier versions are deposited at doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/2S3E6.

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Michael Darius Eastwood conceived and directs this research programme and is the author of this work. Across the programme, he has used more than six AI systems in parallel, under his own instructions, to stress-test his arguments, identify possible errors, and assist in preparing draft text from his own outlines. He determines what is adopted, revised or rejected and takes responsibility for the published content. These systems are tools, not authors.

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A Version history and corrections

Every version and correction, with its date. Notes from earlier versions are kept as printed; the positions they name refer to the earlier layout, which Table 3 maps to this edition.

A.1 Version 2.7

Paper IV.d v2.7, 21 October 2026. This version brings the paper up to date with the internal code review of October 2026 and narrows its claim to what the comparison shows: the reported direction of the alignment-depth trend did not hold between the v4 and v5 runs, which differed in their scoring protocol and in their responses, prompts, token allowances, depth levels, panels and, for Gemini, model. The paper no longer says that the comparison isolates blinding, that the v5 direction is the correct one, or that GPT-5.4 is a control, and the three sentences that called blinding an established necessity now carry the programme's reading and the open question (Section 9, the caption of Figure 1 and Section 10.1).

It states the March run as it ran: the panel excluded the subject model and no other, and one judge model scored twice (Section 4, 'The panel as run'); the paraphrasing models were drawn from the judges' pool, some paraphrases came from the subject's own developer and some carried the paraphraser's reasoning (Section 4.1); the paraphrase step's output cap cut the deepest answers in the three runs that read flat or negative, the d and p values treat prompt-repeated entries as independent, the DeepSeek row is not a demonstrated reversal, and the fourth v4 subject, Claude Opus 4.6, is reported beside the three compared (Section 5); one judge's scores in the three early files were read from prose, and the consensus rule is a candidate mechanism (Section 10). Section 4 records how often DeepSeek V3.2's v4 responses at the exhaustive level reached the v4 reasoning cap, and that the public v5 runner is a later revision than the one that produced four of its six result files. The conditions that would defeat the paper's hypothesis now count the responses, the token allowances and depth levels, the Gemini model, the aggregation rule, the paraphrase step's output cap and launderers who also judged among the confounds, and ask for a replication on identical responses; the recommended protocol adds a check of preserved meaning and length on every paraphrase (Sections 10.1 and 8). The laundering-fallback flag, whose meaning version 2.6 left open, is stated plainly as a known false positive of the early build that shows nothing about the paraphrase step. The two experiments are dated from their own evidence (Section 4, Appendix B).

Figure 1 is redrawn from the table's values: the drawing of version 2.6 showed Gemini's v4 coefficient as +0.311, where the table, after Papers IV.a and IV.b, gives +0.275; its title and its sentence 'Blinding is not optional; it is the measurement instrument' are withdrawn. Finding 1 no longer names study-y, a cross-family re-scoring of the programme's published results that places v5 outside its class; the test of the published contrasts is a re-analysis that is to be registered. A related-work section now credits the earlier work on model judges and on safety-relevant behaviour against reasoning length, each work in its own terms and linked to its source. Laws IV and V are stated as registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103 of the theory registration, not yet tested. No registered law, prediction, kill condition or dependency changes; no result is added or removed; no date of any claim moves.

This edition is typeset in LaTeX. The front matter of version 2.6 moves into the sections and appendices that Table 3 lists; the abstract is rewritten within arXiv's limit; a related-work section is added as Section 2, so Sections 2 to 7 of version 2.6 become Sections 3 to 8, and its Section 8 becomes Section 10; a section on what the paper does and does not show gathers the scope statement, the frame line and the epistemic status; the heading of Section 6 now names a change of direction, and that of Finding 1 says the direction did not hold, rather than a flip of sign or a reversal by blinding; the heading of Section 10.1 names the hypothesis it tests, and Finding 2 is set as a recommendation; the copyright line is shortened; links to the author's documents point to their OSF DOIs; numeric ranges are written with 'to'. No number, date or DOI changes except as this entry records.

A.2 Earlier corrections and dated notes

This paper and Laws IV and V, 3 October 2026. The theory has been stated with five laws since 24 September 2026. Law IV, the ARC Persistence Law, is carried by proposition P15, and Law V, the ARC Embedding Law, by propositions P12 and P21. The three propositions are registered; neither law is registered as a law, and neither has been tested. Their mathematics is set out in Laws IV and V: the mathematics, version 1.0, of 3 October 2026. This paper shows why the evaluation protocol must be controlled: for two model families, the direction of the alignment-depth relationship changed between the unblinded v4 protocol and the blinded v5 protocol, while a null-control family held flat. Because v4 and v5 differ in more than one protocol component, the paper does not isolate the causal effect of blinding. Nor is it evidence that a persistence or an embedding prediction survived a test. The theory's registration requires blind scoring for every one of its twenty-two propositions, P15, P12 and P21 among them, so any judged test of Law IV or Law V depends on blind scoring of the kind this paper examines. No result in this paper is a deciding test of P15, P12 or P21. Naming the two laws changes nothing printed here: the results, their dates and their limits stand as they were.

Note (18 October 2026). The dated note above, of 3 October 2026, names P15 as the proposition that carries Law IV, as the theory then stood. Under version 1.103 of the theory registration, P15 is the retention limb of Law IV, whose comparison limb has no registered proposition yet; P12 and P21 are carried by Law V (Appendix D). The note above and every date in it are unchanged.

Note (3 October 2026). One sentence above is corrected in place, and this note records what it printed before. The epistemic status line read "What this programme names Laws are conjectures under registered adversarial test"; it now gives Laws I to III and Laws IV and V their separate status. No result, limit or date of any claim in this paper changes.

The epistemic status line, as printed in version 2.6. "What this programme names Laws are conjectures. Laws I to III are under registered adversarial test. Laws IV and V were added on 24 September 2026; the predictions that carry them are registered, the laws themselves are not yet registered, and neither has been tested. Every quantity in this paper is operationally defined, and established-law standing is claimed nowhere. The registered programme exists to earn that standing, or lose it, by measurement, replication and survived refutation." Version 2.7 states Laws I to III as laws under test, registered on 8 September 2026, with no registered test of any law yet returning a verdict, and Laws IV and V as registered as laws on 15 October 2026 in version 1.103 of the theory registration (Section 9).

A.3 Version history

Paper IV.d v2.6 (5 October 2026): the title now follows the programme's uniform order (paper, its law or framework, its own title), *Paper IV.d · The ARC Theory · The Effect of Blinding on AI Alignment Evaluation*; until this version it read *Paper IV.d: The Effect of Blinding on AI Alignment Evaluation*. The plate beneath the author line now gives the paper's place in the programme in the words of the programme's map. Mentions of the programme's papers in this paper now carry their uniform titles. No registered law, prediction, kill condition or dependency changes; no result is added; no date of any claim moves.

Paper IV.d v2.5 (3 October 2026): a dated note places the paper against Laws IV and V and records that it is a test of neither. A dated note after the paragraph on dated predictions, recorded on 25 August 2026, gives the state of registration as read on 3 October 2026. The epistemic status line gives Laws I to

III and Laws IV and V their separate status, and a dated note records what it printed before. Citations are linked: mentions of the author's papers in the running text go to their DOIs, the book named in the byline to its own page, and other cited works to their official sources. The withdrawal of Eden Engineering of 14 July 2026 was reversed on 19 September 2026, and its version 6.3 is published. No registered law, prediction, kill condition or dependency changes; no result is added; no date of any claim moves.

v2.4 (13 September 2026): The provenance note at the end has been corrected for accuracy. No claim, date, result or status has changed.

v2.3 (2 September 2026): the v4 Gemini coefficient now given as +0.275, after Papers IV.a and IV.b, with the figure's +0.311 flagged; the Section 4 table now points to the recomputation note in Paper IV.a, which leaves every direction as it stood; the Section 8 concession that more than one protocol component moved between versions now appears in the abstract and in Finding 1; the limitations gain the laundering-fallback flag as the archived files hold it, true on every scored entry for three subjects, two of which are the reversal cases; each of the three sister papers now cited under its own DOI rather than this paper's; Constitutional AI attributed to Bai et al. (2022); the summary description no longer cut short; Eden Engineering shown as withdrawn.

v2.2 (23 August 2026): epistemic-status declaration and standing covenant added, version-numbering convention adopted; scientific content otherwise unchanged; v2.1 tightens model-naming and reporting discipline (canonical model strings in the Figure 1 caption, em-dash removal, study-y draft-registration reference at Finding 1, exploratory framing for section 6 implications); v2.0 finalised the canonical publication framing for the blinding result and superseded the earlier v1.1 export.

A.4 Where the earlier layout now stands

Table 3. Where each block of the version 2.6 layout stands in this edition.

Block in the earlier layout	Where it stands in this edition
Registration line and format links above the title	Appendix D.2 (the registration at version 1.103); the format links are website navigation and are not set
Summary panel: label, title, card text, dates, copy of the abstract, related reading	Title block and first-page footnote; the card text and the abstract copy are not repeated; related reading is not set
Title, theory-position plate and subtitle	Title, secondary line and first-page footnote; the plate's words in Appendix D
Byline and meta block (affiliation, DOI, version, companion papers, code and data)	Author block, first-page footnote, Section 1, Appendix D.3 and Code and data
Abstract	Abstract, rewritten within arXiv's limit
Scope of Claim and the frame line	Section 9
Section 1	Section 1
(new)	Section 2, Related work
Section 2	Section 3
Section 3 and 3.1	Section 4 and 4.1
Section 4, Figure 1 and Finding 1	Section 5

Block in the earlier layout	Where it stands in this edition
Section 5	Section 6
Section 6	Section 7
Section 7 and Finding 2	Section 8
Section 8 and 8.1	Section 10 and 10.1
Section 9 and the bottom line	Section 11
References	References
Version history in the footer	Appendix A.3
Read-alongside line	Section 1, last paragraph
Canonical links	Code and data
How to cite	Not set; the DOI is in the first-page footnote
Dated predictions and this paper	Appendix B.2
Epistemic status	Section 9; the earlier wording in Appendix A.2
This paper and Laws IV and V, and its note	Appendix A.2
Copyright	After the acknowledgements
Standing covenant	End of Section 10.1
Provenance note	Acknowledgements

B Priority record

Each dated record bearing on this paper, with its kind of timestamp (Table 4): a deposit dated by its server (an OSF upload or a GitHub push), a commit date written by the committer, a time written into a result file by the code that ran, or a date written inside a document. No kind is presented as stronger than it is.

B.1 Dated records

Table 4. Dated records bearing on this paper, each with its kind of timestamp.

Date and time	Record	Kind of timestamp
22 January 2026, 02:57:02 UTC	Twelve capability problems with their answers (ARC01 to ARC12 of v5's capability ladder), in the code of an earlier one-model run	GitHub push; OSF upload 22 January 2026, 23:44:03 UTC
22 January 2026, 05:37:46 UTC	Paper III experimental design, first version: alignment through constraints stays flat, through values scales with depth; withdrawn on 23 January 2026, 00:35:24 UTC	GitHub push
9 February 2026, 19:46:58 UTC	Paper III version 6.1: the prediction the experiments tested, public without break from here, with a general measurement protocol	GitHub push; OSF upload 9 February 2026, 20:06:08 UTC
13 February 2026, 05:15:21 UTC	Paper III version 8.2: F13, the criterion that would refute the prediction	OSF upload

Date and time	Record	Kind of timestamp
22 February 2026, 07:01:00 UTC	White Paper III version 9.0 and Eden Protocol Engineering version 4.0: the criterion and a statistical specification	GitHub push; OSF uploads at 08:15:13 and 08:16:06 UTC
11 March 2026, 00:01:35	First v4 record	Written into the result file by the code that ran (no zone stated; read as UK time, which is UTC in March)
11 March 2026, 07:12:13 to 12 March 2026, 11:27:39	First and last v5 records	As above
12 March 2026	The pipeline summary whose values Table 2 prints	Date written in the document
16 March 2026	This paper first published (the date printed in it); GitHub commit 135bf0e1, 18:32:28 UTC, adds the first HTML of Papers IV.c and IV.d	Date written inside the document; commit date written by the committer
16 March 2026, 18:48:07 UTC	Runners v1 to v5 and the v5 result files first public; the v4 result files followed at 18:55:28 UTC (both pushes are no longer in the main branch's history and are served by their hashes)	GitHub push
17 March 2026, 01:40:43 UTC	This paper's OSF component made public	OSF server log
17 March 2026, 02:08:38 UTC	The v5 runner on OSF (SHA-256 `9f1ab3a8135bdaf76343e8d2263b4739b97e36b67652d41ef44e62c525c1fa17`)	OSF file-version server time
20 March 2026, 17:05:32 UTC	This paper's PDF, revision 1, on OSF (it prints "Draft v1.1 · 12 March 2026" and "First published 16 March 2026")	OSF server; the printed dates are dates written inside the document
2 September 2026	Recomputation note in Paper IV.a, Section 3.1, which alters no direction in Table 2	Date written in a document
8 September, 13 September and 15 October 2026	The theory registration: registered at version 1.100, updated at version 1.102, updated at version 1.103	OSF registration and its approved updates

The comparison of the two protocols that this paper reports is dated by the runs' own records and by the first publication of 16 March 2026.

B.2 Dated predictions and this paper (recorded 25 August 2026)

1 dated artefact bearing on this paper is catalogued row by row in the programme's machine register: 1 dated result file whose headers freeze depth configurations, planted expected answers and the four-layer blinding protocol before the responses they score, timestamped to the second in their own metadata. Each row names its file in the public repository with its date basis, so any reader can check the ordering without trusting this page. The programme's full dated chain, from the sealed manuscript bundle of 8 December 2024 through the printed prediction appendices of 2 January 2026 and the March 2026 preregistration folder to the standing unproven wagers, is assembled in the dated predictions register, together with its machine-readable twin. Forward statements and retrospective matches are never summed. "Registered" is used only for an accepted registry submission, and that submission click remains outstanding across the programme; "preregistered in substance" is used, always with its qualifier and always beside its attestation class, for a prediction whose text was public and timestamped before its outcome existed, as the

twelve-row manifest committed at 00:19 UTC on 17 March 2026 was, twenty-three minutes before its fits. The running record behind this paper's experimental lineage is the programme's live laboratory notebook: commenced 10 March 2026, 206 pages, updated in real time as these experiments ran, recording their failures as they happened. (The dated predictions register: DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/C3NTF; the working report: osf.io/j6mkb.)

Note (3 October 2026). The paragraph above was recorded on 25 August 2026. As read on 3 October 2026, one registration has been accepted: the theory's own, registered on 8 September 2026 and updated on 13 September 2026, which registers twenty-two propositions. One study unit, the corrector-class audit (unit 06), was submitted for registration on OSF on 1 October 2026; its approval period at OSF was still running on 3 October 2026, and it was not yet public. Every other study unit is a draft awaiting the author's submission. Sixty-five of the programme's designs, unit 06 among them, are preregistered by timestamp, the first anchored on 12 August 2026 in Bitcoin block 962066. Unchanged: the paragraph above and every date in it.

Note (18 October 2026). The paragraphs above were recorded on 25 August and 3 October 2026. As read on 18 October 2026, the theory's registration (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/P8CKQ) was registered on 8 September 2026 at version 1.100 and updated on 13 September 2026 at version 1.102 and on 15 October 2026 at version 1.103, which registers Laws IV and V as laws, untested; the texts of versions 1.100 and 1.102 stay frozen beside it. The first registered study, Unit 06 (a classification audit, DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/RV2B5), was registered on 1 October 2026, ran on 6 October 2026, and is reported in full as administratively incomplete, with no verdict claimed (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/4BPHG); it tests no law. Unchanged: the paragraphs above and every date in them.

C Notation and glossary

Table 5 gives each symbol with the place it is defined, and Table 6 the paper's terms in plain language.

C.1 Symbols

Table 5. Symbols, with the place each is defined.

Symbol	Meaning
ρ	Spearman's rank correlation of alignment score with reasoning depth, as each run's pipeline reports it: v4's statistic, over depth levels, and printed beside d in v5, over realised reasoning tokens (Section 5)
d	Cohen's d between the shallowest and the deepest depth level of a model's scored entries, in v5 (Section 5)
p	The p-value the pipeline printed; in v5 not one test (Section 5)
v4, v5	The earlier unblinded experiment and the later, unregistered March 2026 run of the same alignment-depth question (Section 4)

C.2 Plain-language glossary

Table 6. Plain-language glossary.

Term	In plain English
Model judge	A model that scores another model's answer; also called a scorer.
Panel	The judges that score one entry; in v5, six or seven scores from five or six distinct models (Table 1).
Alignment score	The consensus score the panel gives an answer under the ARC-Align rubric of Paper IV.c.
Depth level	A setting of how much a model reasons before it answers: a reasoning parameter, a token budget or an instruction prefix, by provider.
Blinding	Hiding from the judge which model wrote an answer and under which condition. The v5 protocol's blinding steps are described as designed; whether they hid the source is unmeasured (Section 10).
Identity masking	Removing the model's name and the depth condition from what the judge sees.
Response laundering	Rewriting an answer, here in two passes by other models, to reduce cues to its source while keeping its meaning; v5 recorded no check of preserved meaning (Section 4.1).
Laundering-fallback flag	A field set on every paraphrased entry of the three early-build v5 files; a known false positive of that build, which shows nothing about the paraphrase step (Section 10).
Self-exclusion	Leaving the subject model off its own panel: by model in v5, by developer in the successor suite's design.
Tier-weighted consensus	The panel's mean weighted by each judge's tier; in v5, where the judges' standard deviation exceeded 15 points, the lower of that mean and the median.
Source-recognition test	A test, with a positive control, of whether judges can tell which model wrote an answer; not reported for v5.
Comparison case	A model with no significant trend in either run, read beside the others; with no equivalence margin set, not a control (Section 5).
Unregistered run	A run made under no registration on a public registry. The March 2026 runs were not registered; the prediction they tested was public before they ran (Section 4).
Registered	Accepted by a public registry (OSF) and read back.
Preregistered by timestamp	A design whose text was fixed by a dated, verifiable timestamp before its run, without a registry submission.
Condition A	The theory registration's rule that scoring be blind to the condition for every proposition it registers (Appendix D).
Law under test	A law of the ARC Theory that no registered test has yet decided.

D The paper's place in the ARC Theory and the programme

Where this paper sits among the developments of the programme (Table 7), with the relation its own text supports and no stronger.

D.1 The theory's laws and this paper

Table 7. The paper's place among the developments of the programme.

Development	Relation	Where the paper states it
Recursive Dynamics, the field the author founded	The paper belongs to the field's founding theory	First-page footnote
The ARC Theory	One of its ARC/Eden experiments: its finding on the measurement of alignment	Section 9
Laws I to III (the ARC Principle, the ARC Co-Scaling Law, the ARC Ceiling), registered on 8 September 2026, laws under test	None: the result depends on none of them	Sections 1 and 11
Law IV, the ARC Persistence Law, and Law V, the ARC Embedding Law, registered as laws on 15 October 2026 (version 1.103), not yet tested, their mathematics in development	Informs: condition A binds the propositions under both laws, so any judged test of either depends on scoring of the kind examined here; decides neither	Appendix D.2
Condition A of the theory registration	Informs: version 1.103 reads this paper's finding at the width the paper gives it	Appendix D.2
The Eden Protocol	None: the result does not depend on it	Section 11
The HARI Treaty	None stated in this paper	None

D.2 Condition A and Laws IV and V

The theory registration (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/P8CKQ) was registered on 8 September 2026 at version 1.100 and updated on 13 September 2026 at version 1.102 and on 15 October 2026 at version 1.103. Its condition A makes blinding universal: "The scoring must be blind to the condition for every one of the twenty-two, including the classification audits, where the classifier must be blind to which class favours the framework. Nothing here can be supported or refuted by an unblinded judgement." Version 1.103 places this paper's finding beside that condition, reads it "at the width that paper gives it", and states that "the effect of blinding on its own is the controlled comparison still to run". Laws IV and V were added on 24 September 2026 and registered as laws by version 1.103; neither has been tested, and their mathematics is in development (DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/4B3VT, version 1.1 of 7 October 2026). Under version 1.103, P15 is the retention limb of Law IV, whose comparison limb has no registered proposition yet, and P12 and P21 are carried by Law V. Condition A binds all three, so any judged test of either law depends on blind scoring of the kind this paper examines; no result in this paper is a deciding test of P12, P15 or P21. The register of operational definitions is DOI 10.17605/OSF.IO/GVQ82.

D.3 Companion papers

The v5 run is reported in Paper IV.a (alignment response classes under inference-time depth) and Paper IV.b (alignment saturation), and its instrument is specified in Paper IV.c; Paper IX situates the result in the wider programme. Papers IV.a (version 1.9) and IV.c (version 1.10) predate the code review of October 2026; where they call the v4 to v5 change a reversal under blinding, or the v5 jury 'self-excluding', this paper's narrower account governs until their next versions.